2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Elizabeth Favela

Grade / Grado 7

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Brittany Rosales

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Email

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- ○ Father / Padre
- ○ Grandfather / Abuelo
- ○ Stepdad / Padrasto
- ◉ Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

What an important father-figure means to me is, being by your side forever. Understanding how you feel throughout your hardest times and your best times, making you feel seen, not giving up on you till you find yourself. Those qualities and many more describes my older cousin. She is very compassionate towards many people. My cousin helped me find myself during my hardest times, she showed me the real meaning of a real father figure. She taught me how to communicate about my feelings to other people other than her. One day I will have to communicate to someone else other than her which is not easy. I struggle a lot trying to communicate about my feelings to others, so knowing I was able to tell her about my life story really changed me as a person. She helped me realize that children have feelings too and should also be seen. She helped me heal from my past relationships from many people i struggled moving on with because of my attachment issues. My cousin is seen as a father-figure to me because everytime I need to talk to her about my emotions she lets me vent my heart out. She showed me listening to music helps heal the soul, and from there on I always listen to music to help me get my thoughts off my head. She helped me face my fears and helped me with my mental health. My cousin really does make me feel seen , everytime she listens to me explaning how hard life gets. She makes me feel some type of way ive never felt before which is a happy type of emotion. My cousin really tops all the qualities you need to accomplish to be seen as a father-figure.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.